

An Autistic Adult in Your Coaching / Gym / Club

For gym instructors, running-club leaders & sports coaches — supporting an autistic adult.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means an adult's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." For a working autistic adult, your gym, class or club can be essential recovery — a place of routine, focus and regulation after a high-load day at work. Many will mask all day and need the session to be low-demand and predictable, not another performance. Lean into structure, clarity and quiet, and your coaching becomes genuine wellbeing support.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Same time, same machine, same routine, every visit	Predictability and flow are regulation , not "rigidity"
Wants the plan in writing; hates ad-hoc changes	Single-channel, literal planning — gives control
Comes straight from work, depleted or "flat"	Likely end-of-day burnout/masking fatigue
Headphones in, avoids chat	Managing sensory and social load — not unfriendly
Masters technique deeply; asks detailed "why" questions	Monotropic strength and engagement

Try this

- **Offer written plans and predictable structure;** tell them what the session is before it starts.
- **One cue at a time, with reasons;** allow processing time; show the movement.
- **Respect headphones, quiet and routine** — these are regulation tools; don't push unsolicited chat.
- **Play to depth and interest** — technique, programming, a single discipline often suits.
- **Check in literally and briefly;** offer individual over forced group formats where possible.

Avoid this

- Surprise partner-work, "motivational" shouting, or last-minute class changes.
- Reading headphones or a quiet routine as rudeness or lack of effort.
- Equating a flat, depleted session with "not trying."

When to get more support

Be alert to **burnout signs** (chronic exhaustion, withdrawal, dropping skills) and signpost occupational health / GP support if welcome. A flexible, low-demand membership helps an autistic adult keep moving even through a hard patch at work.

If the person is a woman

Late-diagnosed women mask heavily and may present as “fine” while privately exhausted; don’t let a competent exterior override signs of overload.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4, sports & coaching), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Michaud & Harvey (2025, physical-activity scoping review); Dwyer (2025); Knight (2021). Full citations are in the source drafts.